

PRODUCT DOCUMENTATION

# Work About Work

Framework Document

|               |                                    |
|---------------|------------------------------------|
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## Purpose of This Document

This document defines the "Work About Work" framework: the conceptual and empirical foundation underpinning the diagnostic tool, the calculator model, and all associated consulting outputs. It is the source of truth for claims made in the tool, in client conversations, and in published content.

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## The Core Claim

**Work about work is a process defect.** Not an inconvenience, not a personality issue, not an inevitable cost of doing business.

A process defect, in operational terms, has three defining characteristics:

|            |                                                                                                                 |
|------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Measurable | The time lost to coordination overhead can be quantified at the individual, team, and organisational level.     |
| Systemic   | It compounds across roles and levels. It is caused by how work is structured, not by how hard people work.      |
| Avoidable  | With deliberate system redesign, a significant portion of coordination overhead can be eliminated or automated. |

Work about work meets all three criteria. That is what makes it a defect rather than a feature.

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## Definition

**Work about work** is the lifecycle management of tasks rather than the tasks themselves.

It includes:

- Meetings and coordination:** Attending, preparing for, and following up on meetings that primarily exist to manage the flow of information rather than make decisions.
- Internal communications:** Drafting, triaging, and responding to status updates, check-ins, and administrative messages.
- Information retrieval:** Searching across fragmented systems for documents, context, or decisions that should be immediately accessible.

*These activities are individually harmless. Collectively, they represent a structural drain on organisational capacity.*

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## The Empirical Baseline

The framework is grounded in two primary sources: Microsoft 365 telemetry and APQC benchmarks (composite estimate across 982 knowledge workers).

| Category                                                | Hours / week |
|---------------------------------------------------------|--------------|
| Meetings, coordination, notes, follow-ups               | 10.0 hrs     |
| Internal communications (email, triage, status updates) | 3.6 hrs      |
| Information retrieval across systems                    | 2.8 hrs      |
| Total                                                   | 16.4 hrs     |

That is approximately **two full working days per week** spent on coordination overhead, not on the work itself. This figure is a conservative composite representing the average knowledge worker in a typical enterprise environment.

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## Why This Is a System Design Problem

The instinct is to treat coordination overhead as a people problem: people are disorganised, meetings run long, communication is unclear. This misdiagnoses the defect.

Coordination overhead is high not because individuals are ineffective, but because the systems they operate inside create friction by design:

- Information is fragmented across tools, so retrieval requires manual search
- Decisions lack clear owners, so alignment requires repeated meetings
- Status is not visible by default, so it must be communicated manually
- Processes are undocumented, so every exception requires a conversation

*These are structural conditions. They respond to structural interventions, not to individual productivity advice.*

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## The Improvement Framework: DMAIC Applied to Coordination

The framework applies the DMAIC continuous improvement methodology, traditionally used in manufacturing and operations, to knowledge work coordination.

| Stage   | Application                                                                     |
|---------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Define  | Identify the coordination activities consuming the most time in your team       |
| Measure | Quantify hours lost and cost of overhead using the calculator model             |
| Improve | Redesign the highest-friction processes; introduce AI tooling where appropriate |
| Control | Monitor adoption, measure reclaimed capacity, adjust over time                  |

*This is not AI for AI's sake. It is operational engineering applied to a category of waste that has historically been accepted as invisible.*

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## Where AI Creates Measurable Gains

Applied conservatively to the 16.4-hour baseline, research-backed AI adoption produces the following efficiency gains:

| Category | Efficiency gain | Mechanism |
|----------|-----------------|-----------|
|----------|-----------------|-----------|

|                         |        |                                                 |
|-------------------------|--------|-------------------------------------------------|
| Meetings and follow-up  | 25–30% | Automated note capture, synthesis, action lists |
| Internal communications | 30–40% | Reduction in drafting and triage time           |
| Information retrieval   | 25–35% | AI-assisted search across fragmented systems    |

These are **midpoint, conservative estimates**, not best-case scenarios. Derived from peer-reviewed research including Noy and Zhang (MIT) and Harvard Business School's *Navigating the Jagged Technological Frontier*.

Net result: approximately **4–5 hours reclaimed per person, per week**.

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## What 4–5 Hours Actually Means

At the individual level, 4–5 hours reclaimed per week is:

- One uninterrupted morning of deep work
- A measurable reduction in context-switching and administrative fatigue
- Time redirected to strategy, problem-solving, and decision-making

*"A 20-person team reclaiming 4–5 hours each gains the equivalent of 2–3 additional FTEs of capacity, without hiring."*

This is the number that makes the business case. It is also the number that anchors the calculator.

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## What This Framework Is Not Claiming

To maintain credibility with sceptical stakeholders, the framework explicitly does not claim:

- ✗ That AI alone solves coordination problems
- ✗ That every organisation will reclaim 4–5 hours per person
- ✗ That technology replaces governance, process design, or leadership judgment
- ✗ That results are immediate or automatic
- ✗ That a single benchmark applies uniformly across all roles and industries

The framework claims that coordination overhead is measurable, that AI is a legitimate improvement lever when applied within a structured methodology, and that organisations who treat this as a **system design problem**, rather than a people problem, will outperform those who do not.

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## The Consulting Implication

The diagnostic tool exists to make this framework tangible for a specific team, in under 60 seconds.

**The Calculator:** Surfaces the cost of the defect at the team level

**The Audit:** Identifies where the defect is most acute: meeting types, decision clarity, AI maturity

**The Conversation:** Where the redesign begins

*"Technology alone doesn't improve outcomes. Systems, governance, and transparency do. AI simply expands what those systems can automate."*

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## Sources

- Microsoft 365 telemetry: meeting and communication time data
- APQC: knowledge worker benchmark survey (n=982)
- Noy and Zhang (MIT): generative AI productivity study
- Harvard Business School: Navigating the Jagged Technological Frontier